Young-onset dementia

Find out what young-onset dementia is, including the causes and symptoms, and how it is diagnosed and treated.

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Young-onset dementia

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What is young-onset dementia?

There are around 900,000 people in the UK living with dementia, and the likelihood of developing dementia increases significantly with age. When a person develops dementia before the age of 65, this is known as 'young-onset dementia'. Over 70,800 people in the UK are living with young-onset dementia.

Like all people with dementia, younger people may experience a wide range of symptoms, especially in the early stages of dementia. However, they are likely to need different support to older people. This section looks at the types of dementia that younger people can have and the effects of these. It also includes information on where people can find support.

If you have recently been diagnosed with young-onset dementia, see booklet 688, Young-onset dementia: Understanding your diagnosis.

Dementia in younger people

People whose symptoms started when they were under the age of 65 are often known as 'younger people with dementia' or as having young-onset dementia. This is not for a biological reason, but is based on the fact that 65 was the usual age of retirement for many people.

People sometimes use the terms 'early-onset dementia' or 'working-age dementia'. This information uses the term 'young-onset dementia'.

Dementia is caused by a wide range of different diseases. This is similar for younger and older people ('late-onset dementia'), but there are important differences in how dementia affects younger people. These include the following:

- A wider range of diseases cause young-onset dementia.
- A younger person is much more likely to have a rarer form of dementia.
- Younger people with dementia are less likely to have memory loss as one of their first symptoms.
- Young-onset dementia is more likely to cause problems with movement, walking, co-ordination or balance.
- Young-onset dementia is more likely to be inherited (passed on through genes) – this affects up to 10% of younger people with dementia.
- Many younger people with dementia don't have any other serious or long-term health conditions.

Someone who is diagnosed under the age of 65 needs to adjust to living with a long-term condition as a younger person. They might be concerned about the effects this will have on their family, relationships, finances and daily life. They may also be worried that any children or siblings will have a higher risk of developing dementia.

There is more information about these issues throughout this section.

Debbie's story: 'Not enough people are aware of early onset dementia, never mind understand it'

Real stories

At 50 years old, Debbie was told that she had mixed dementia. Following her diagnosis, the stigma surrounding dementia has had a significant impact on her life. But Debbie believes people's attitudes towards people affected by dementia can be changed.

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Dementia Support Line

0333 150 3456

Our dementia advisers are here for you.

Dementia Support Forum

Online community

Visit our online community to get advice, share experiences, connect.

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2. What causes young-onset dementia?

Categories

Risk Factors, Genetics, Young-onset dementia

Further reading

What kind of information would you like to read?
Use the button below to choose between help, advice and real stories.

Decide what you see

Younger people with dementia need affordable care home options

Real stories

Paul Harvey, in Essex, has young-onset dementia and worries about the pressure that residential care costs would put on his family.

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Parenting and family life after being diagnosed with Alzheimer's at 50

Real stories

Elaine in Surrey is making the most of family life after being diagnosed with young-onset Alzheimer's disease.

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How many people have dementia in the UK?

Information

There are currently estimated to be 982,000 people with dementia in the UK, but more than a third of people with the condition do not have a diagnosis. The number is expected to rise to 1.4 million by 2040.

10 May 2024

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Our regular support email includes the latest dementia advice, resources, real stories and more.

Email (required) | **First name** (required) | **Last name** (required)

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